

Stories of a Near Future

A 4-day writing retreat where leadership teams draft the 2030 they would rather have — and stress-test it against evidence.

Every module runs three tracks at once.

NARRATIVE

You stopped forecasting and started writing. The 2030 you wrote is now a document your team can argue with.

COGNITIVE

*Preferable-futures ontology: writing → evidence → back-cast → decision.
Fiction as due diligence.*

IDENTITY

From strategist to storyteller-with-receipts.

Why this matters

Establish the emotional stakes of the future being written.

"Whose 2030 are you writing? Whose are you not?"

01. The Beneficiary List

20 min

Name who benefits and who doesn't.

Prompt: List 10 beneficiaries of your imagined 2030. Then 10 non-beneficiaries.

Debrief: Ask: 'Which list did you write faster?'

02. First-Person Dispatch

45 min

Write as someone living in 2030.

Prompt: First-person 1-page dispatch from 2030, as a stakeholder — not you.

Debrief: Read aloud. Only listen.

03. The Cost Question

15 min

Name what this future costs.

Prompt: Every good future costs something. Write one paragraph: 'This future cost us ____'.

Debrief: Debate as a group: 'Is that cost bearable?'

The reframe

Break linear extrapolation with a discontinuity exercise.

"What breaks between now and 2030 that you're not modelling?"

01. Discontinuity Cards

30 min

Force a break in the timeline.

Prompt: Draw a random discontinuity card. Rewrite your dispatch integrating it.

Debrief: Ask: 'Which cards did the group refuse to draw twice?'

02. The Weird Signal

30 min

Bring evidence of the discontinuity happening now.

Prompt: Each person shares one weak signal from the last 6 months.

Debrief: Cluster signals. Vote on which are most under-priced.

03. Time Slice

45 min

Rewrite the dispatch from a different year.

Prompt: Rewrite the same scene as 2027, then 2033. Compare.

Debrief: Ask: 'Which version scared you more?'

Organize complexity

Introduce back-casting as the framework linking story to decision.

"What would have to be true in 2027 for your 2030 to be true?"

01. The Back-Cast

40 min

Fill the middle.

Prompt: Given your 2030 dispatch, list the 5 milestones of 2028, 2027, 2026.

Debrief: Ask: 'Which milestone is missing from your current roadmap?'

02. Evidence Column

30 min

Every milestone needs a source.

Prompt: Add one column: what evidence today makes each milestone plausible?

Debrief: Circle the milestones with no evidence. Those are your bets.

03. The Cost Column

20 min

What must you sacrifice at each milestone?

Prompt: Add one column: what must be stopped or shrunk?

Debrief: Ask: 'Are you willing?'

Pattern discovery

Peer critique. Fiction as due diligence.

"What holes did other people find in your future?"

01. Story Court

60 min

Present a dispatch. Get cross-examined.

Prompt: One team presents. Two teams cross-examine. One team defends.

Debrief: Change roles every 30 min.

02. The Skeptic's Read

20 min

Read one dispatch as a skeptical journalist.

Prompt: Write a 1-paragraph skeptical review of another team's dispatch.

Debrief: Give it to the author. Silent read.

03. Insurance Question

25 min

What would you insure this future against?

Prompt: List 5 risks and the price of insuring against each.

Debrief: Ask: 'Which insurance can't you afford to skip?'

Commitment

Turn the surviving story into a decision.

"What one decision does this story now require?"

01. The Story-to-Decision Bridge

30 min

Compress story into a decision.

Prompt: Write: 'If our 2030 is true, then before ___ we must decide ___.'

Debrief: Read aloud. Notice repetition.

02. Bet Sizing

25 min

Size the bet against the evidence.

Prompt: For each decision: what's the smallest bet that would test it?

Debrief: Publish the bet sizes.

03. Story Handoff

10 min

Give your story to someone outside the room.

Prompt: Name one person who needs this story before the quarter ends.

Debrief: Schedule the handoff before leaving.

How the arc unfolds.

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| 01 | Day 1 — Stakes
6h | Love | <i>First dispatches read.</i> |
| 02 | Day 2 — Break
6h | Magic | <i>Discontinuity integrated.</i> |
| 03 | Day 3 morning — Back-cast
4h | Calm | <i>Milestones + evidence + cost.</i> |
| 04 | Day 3 afternoon — Court
4h | Open | <i>Story survives court.</i> |
| 05 | Day 4 — Decide
5h | Free | <i>Decision cards + handoffs.</i> |

COMMITMENT CONTRACT

"What is the one decision your near-future story now requires?"

If our 2030 is _____, then before _____ we must decide _____. The smallest bet that tests this is _____. The person who needs this story is _____.

Witness — The person you named for handoff.